

Before We Move In

The things worth talking through before the keys change hands, with space under each one to write down what we decide.

UNIT	RENT	EACH	DEPOSIT	MOVING
2 bed / 2 bath	R8,800	R4,400	R9,000	Month end

Rent covers sanitation, refuse and security. Electricity and internet are on top.

Agenda

Seven things to run through together. Most of them are quick — the point is simply to have said them out loud once, and to have somewhere to look them up later.

01	Money What we are each putting in at move-in, and what runs monthly	☐
02	Furniture What we each have, what we still need, what we buy together	☐
03	Running the home Cleaning, food, laundry, and how we keep it easy	☐
04	People in the home Guests, and the ministry boundary we have already agreed	☐
05	The view from outside What the church and our families are told, by whom, and when	☐
06	Home, church and everything else Keeping home a place where either of us can raise something small	☐

Notice, and what we would want already agreed

Each item has space for notes underneath it. Anything we leave open goes to the actions block on the last page.

What we are working through

The questions set in italic are the ones worth asking out loud. In the notes box under each item, write what we decided rather than what we discussed — it is much more useful to read back.

01 Money

The split is settled — everything shared, down the middle. Both names are on the lease. What is left is agreeing the numbers and filling in the ones still outstanding.

ONCE-OFF, AT MOVE-IN

ITEM	TOTAL	EACH
Deposit	R9,000	R4,500
First month rent	R8,800	R4,400
Admin fee	R950	R475
Credit check	R150	R75
Total	R18,900	R9,450

EVERY MONTH

ITEM	TOTAL	EACH
Rent	R8,800	R4,400
Electricity	<i>to confirm — may be in the month-end bill</i>	
Gas refill		
Transport — Sundays, shared	R900	R450

ITEM	TOTAL	EACH

Total

Blank rows are for anything we add — groceries, internet, a cleaner, anything else that ends up shared.

STILL TO AGREE

- ☐ Set the monthly household budget, and what it covers.
Groceries, cleaning supplies, toilet paper and the rest — one figure rather than counting individual items.
- ☐ What date does money move each month, relative to both our salary dates?
- ☐ Keep a simple record of who paid what at move-in.
Only matters once, at the end of the lease, when the deposit is refunded. Easier to write down now than to reconstruct later.
- ☐ Confirm what the electricity arrangement actually is once the first bill arrives.

If one of us is short one month, how do we want to handle it?

01 · WHAT WE AGREED

02 Furniture

Rooms are sorted and neither of us has a car, so this is just about what goes in the flat.

- ☐ What each of us is bringing.
- ☐ What is still missing, and roughly what it will cost.

☐ What we buy together, and what stays personal.

☐ For anything bought together — who keeps it if one of us moves on, and whether the other is bought out.

Five minutes now, and nobody has to work it out under pressure later.

☐ Contents insurance — separately, or one policy split between us?

02 • WHAT WE AGREED

03 Running the home

☐ Cleaning: a rota between us, or someone we bring in and split?

Once a week in Johannesburg runs roughly R1,600 a month, about R800 each — worth deciding deliberately rather than drifting into it.

☐ What "tidy" means for the kitchen and the lounge, specifically.

Dishes done the same night, or by the next morning? Easier agreed than assumed.

☐ Food: shared, separate, or shared staples with separate meals.

☐ Fridge and cupboard space.

☐ Laundry — who uses what, when.

☐ Anything either of us needs in order to rest properly at home.

03 • WHAT WE AGREED

04 People in the home

THE LINE ALREADY DRAWN

The flat is not a ministry venue, and church members do not come here. That is already agreed and it is a good line. This part is just about making sure it holds easily, without either of us having to hold it at the door.

- ☐ How does the church come to understand that this address is private, and who handles that?
Better known from the start than corrected after the first person arrives.
- ☐ If someone does turn up, what do we do?
Agreed now, so neither of us has to think on the spot.
- ☐ Is it absolute, or are there exceptions we would both agree to first?
- ☐ Pastoral calls will still happen in the flat even when visitors do not — where are they taken, and what would be helpful from me while they are happening?

OUR OWN GUESTS

- ☐ How much notice before someone comes over?
- ☐ Overnight guests — how often, and how much warning?
- ☐ Family staying over, and for how long.
- ☐ How either of us says "not this week" without it being awkward.

What does a normal week at home look like for each of us?

04 • WHAT WE AGREED

05 The view from outside

People will form a picture of the arrangement either way. Much easier if it is the one we chose.

- ☐ What does the church know, and what will it be told?
- ☐ Who says it, and when?
- ☐ Does anyone in leadership need to know before we move in?
- ☐ Our families — same questions.
- ☐ If someone asks either of us directly, what do we say?
Worth agreeing the wording, so we are not each improvising a slightly different version.

05 · WHAT WE AGREED

06 Home, church and everything else

We already talk easily, which is most of this. The rest is just making sure the flat stays a place where the small things get said early — the dishes, the noise, the thing that has been mildly annoying for a fortnight — and that they land as household things rather than anything bigger.

- ☐ Agree that household matters get sorted between us as equals, whatever else is going on.
- ☐ Keep home conversations and church conversations in separate moments where we can.
- ☐ A short check-in once a month — fifteen minutes, nothing formal.
Small things raised early stay small.

When something small bothers one of us, how do we want to hear about it?

07 If plans change

Not because anything is expected to. It is simply much easier to agree this now, while everyone is looking forward to the move, than to work it out in the middle of whatever prompts it.

NOTICE AND EXIT

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- ☐ How much notice do we give each other if one of us needs to move on? Sixty days is a fair default.
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- ☐ Who finds a replacement, and do we both have to be happy with them?
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- ☐ Who covers the shortfall while the room is empty?
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- ☐ Is the deposit settled at the point someone leaves, or when the lease ends?
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IF WE GET STUCK

Most things will be sorted between the two of us in a five-minute conversation. For anything that will not resolve that way, it helps to have already agreed who we would ask — someone we both trust and both accept, chosen now rather than in the moment.

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- ☐ Name that person.
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THE LEASE IS TWELVE MONTHS

Whatever happens between us, the lease runs its term and we are both on it. Worth one short conversation about what we would want to have already agreed if things changed — who would stay, what notice, and how the costs are handled — so it is a decision we made together in a good moment.

If things changed between us, what would we want to have already agreed about the flat?

07 · WHAT WE AGREED

The six worth writing down

Not a contract. It exists because memory is unreliable, and because a good friendship should never have to survive an argument about who paid for the couch. One page, both signatures, a copy each.

OUR AGREEMENT

1. **Money.** Everything shared is split evenly. The monthly household budget is R____, covering _____. Payment is made ____ by the ____ of each month.
2. **Deposit.** R9,000, R4,500 each. On exit it is refunded in the same proportion, less any damage caused by whoever was responsible for it.
3. **Notice.** Either of us gives the other ____ days' notice before moving out. The person leaving finds a replacement, subject to the other's agreement.
4. **Guests.** ____ hours' notice. Overnight guests: _____. **The flat is not used for ministry and church members do not visit**, except _____.
5. **Joint spending.** Neither of us commits the other to anything over R____ without agreeing it first.
6. **If we get stuck.** Anything we cannot settle between us, we take to _____, whom we both trust. Household decisions are made as equals.

SIGNED & DATE

SIGNED & DATE

Left open, and who is doing it

Anything we could not settle today. A name and a date against each one, or it quietly does not happen.

ACTIONS what · who · by when

Most of this will never be needed. We will settle into a rhythm and the page will sit in a drawer. That is rather the point of it — the arrangements that last are the ones where nobody has to guess what was agreed.